THE HOPE CONNECTION

The Fight

Five Ways a Believer Refuses to Settle — A Companion to "Make No Peace With Sin"

> "But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh."
>
> Galatians 5:16 (ESV)

A Companion Teaching Piece from The Hope Connection

"Meeting others where they are in the Name of Jesus"

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The Fight — Five Ways a Believer Refuses to Settle

A companion teaching piece to “Make No Peace With Sin” — From The Hope Connection — Meeting others where they are in the Name of Jesus

First — So What Do I Do?

The series this piece walks beside asked you to tear up the treaty — to make no peace with sin. A fair question comes back from the kitchen table: *All right. I believe that. Now what do I actually do on Tuesday?* Because the difference between making peace with sin and making war on it is rarely a feeling. Feelings follow. The difference shows up in what a person does with the sin when nobody is watching. There are really only two ways to handle it. The first is **excusing it** — renaming it (a weakness, a habit, just how I'm wired), shrinking it ("not near as bad as what I used to do"), or blaming it on the stress, the childhood, the spouse, the job. The second is **planning to continue in it** — keeping the door unlocked. Keep the number. Keep the app. Keep the route home that passes the old place. Keep the unspoken reservation: *if it gets bad enough, I can always go back.* Different clothes, same treaty. The other handling — the one this piece walks through — is to bring the sin honestly to Christ and actively turn from it. Not perfectly. Not once, in a single burst of resolve. But honestly, actively, and again tomorrow.

One thing has to be nailed down before the first step, or every step that follows will be misunderstood: **none of this earns salvation.** Salvation is by grace alone through faith alone in Christ alone — full stop. The fight described here is fruit, never payment; it is what saved people do, not what people do to get saved. And behind the fight stands a stronger fact than the fight itself: God preserves His people, and God produces holiness in them. These five movements are simply the means He ordinarily uses — the way seed and rain are how a harvest happens. Nobody credits the seed with making the sun shine. If you are His, you are not fighting to become His. You are fighting because you are — and because the One who holds you has not made peace with your sin, even when you were tempted to.

The Five Movements

1. Confess It by Name

Scripture: 1 John 1:9

Vagueness is the last hiding place of a settling heart. "Lord, forgive me for my sins" can be prayed without one single sin coming to mind — and that is the tell. Honest confession names

the thing: what it was, when it happened, who it wounded. Not because God needs the information; He was there. Confession is agreement — calling the thing what God calls it, in God's words, with no lawyer language sanding the edges off. Set the alternative beside it and the fog clears: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:9). Look at the size of that promise. Forgive *and* cleanse — the record wiped and the stain worked out — and not from some unrighteousness, but from *all* of it. And look at its ground: God is *faithful and just* in forgiving confessed sin, not lenient. The debt was carried to a cross and paid; pardon is what justice looks like afterward. The real barrier to specific confession is seldom doubt about God. It is pride — the same pride that preferred the sin now prefers a fog around it. Specificity burns the fog off.

The step: Today, out loud, name one sin to God by its real name — what it was, when it happened, what it cost. Then read 1 John 1:9 back to Him as His answer, and let the verse — not your feelings about it — have the last word.

2. Fix Your Eyes, Walk by the Spirit

Scripture: Hebrews 12:1–2; Galatians 5:16

White-knuckle religion loses, because it fights by staring — at the sin, at the record, at the self — and a runner who studies his own feet stumbles over them. Hebrews changes the picture: "Therefore, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us also lay aside every weight, and sin which clings so closely, and let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God" (Hebrews 12:1–2). Notice the two things laid aside: every *weight* — the not-sinful-in-themselves burdens that tangle the legs, the exhaustion, the clutter, the company and the hours that leave a person defenseless — and the sin that *clings*, the one that knows your name and your schedule. And notice the strategy that replaces the staring: *looking to Jesus.* He is the founder of your faith and its perfecter — its author and its finisher. The race is not won by the man with the tightest jaw; it is run by the man whose eyes stay on the One who started it in him. Paul puts the same medicine in walking clothes: "But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh" (Galatians 5:16). It is promise-shaped, not threat-shaped. The way through is a walk — daily, unglamorous, led — and the Spirit is not a surge of willpower to summon but a Person to ask, to follow, and to be fed by, through the Word, through prayer, through the ordinary means of grace. Feed the walk, and the flesh goes hungry.

The step: This morning, before the known battle arrives, pray it in one breath: "Holy Spirit, I cannot win this in my own strength — walk me through today." Then, when the moment comes, look at the cross before you look at your record.

3. Cut the Supply Lines

Scripture: Matthew 5:29–30

Jesus does not negotiate with sin; He talks like a surgeon. "If your right eye causes you to sin, tear it out and throw it away. For it is better that you lose one of your members than that your whole body be thrown into hell. And if your right hand causes you to sin, cut it off and throw it away. For it is better that you lose one of your members than that your whole body go into hell" (Matthew 5:29–30). He is not commanding self-harm — He is making a cost argument in the strongest picture available. Whatever repeatedly hands you over to sin must be dealt with ruthlessly, and the cost of *not* dealing with it is the higher cost. Every settled sin lives on supply lines. It is fed by something: a route, a phone, an app, an unaccounted hour, an unaccounted twenty dollars, a relationship that always ends in the same place, a first step that everyone involved knows is never the last step. The man making peace keeps his supply lines maintained and calls it realism. The man at war asks one plain question — *where does this thing eat?* — and cuts it there: the routine changes, the access closes, the relationship gets distance, or ends. It will cost something real: convenience, comfort, maybe a friendship, maybe money. Jesus already did that math out loud. Better to lose the member than the whole body. Lose the convenience. Keep the life.

The step: Name the one open door your sin walks through most — and close it today with a deed, not just a decision: delete it, block it, change the route, hand the access to someone you trust. One door. Today.

4. Drag It Into the Light

Scripture: James 5:16; Hebrews 3:13; Galatians 6:1

Sin prefers the dark the way mold prefers a damp cellar; secrecy is its climate control. Confession to God is the first light, and James commands a second one: "Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working" (James 5:16). To *one another* — not to everybody, and not to the whole internet, but to a living person: a mature believer, a pastor, someone who will pray for you and then do the part we usually skip — ask you about it again. James ties the telling to *healing*, and long experience says the same: a sin spoken out loud loses half its authority in the saying of it. Why the daily, mutual watch? "But exhort one another every day, as long as it is called 'today,' that none of you may be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin" (Hebrews 3:13). Sin hardens by deception, and deception is a slow drip nobody feels — so God appoints other people as the early-warning system. And He instructs the receivers, too: "Brothers, if anyone is caught in any transgression, you who are spiritual should restore him in a spirit of gentleness. Keep watch on

yourself, lest you too be tempted" (Galatians 6:1). Restore. Gently. The local church is God's appointed place for all of it — preaching that names the sin, encouragement that carries the fighter, correction that loves too much to look away. I will tell you plain: I learned in recovery rooms, long before I could say it in a church, that the thing you say out loud can no longer own you in silence.

The step: This week, pick one believer you trust and say the true sentence: "Here is the thing I am actually fighting." Ask for two things — prayer, and that they ask you about it again next week.

5. Keep Coming Back

Scripture: Hebrews 12:10–11; Philippians 1:6; Galatians 6:9

Here is where fighters quietly quit — not usually in the fall itself, but in the getting up: the tenth time, the hundredth. The settled man and the stumbling man may fall over the same sin in the same year. The difference is the return. Scripture speaks of God's correction in family language, not courtroom language: "he disciplines us for our good, that we may share his holiness. For the moment all discipline seems painful rather than pleasant, but later it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it" (Hebrews 12:10–11). Discipline is what a Father does with *sons*. Its presence is evidence of belonging; its aim is shared holiness; its harvest is peace — but the harvest word is *later*, and it belongs to those who stay in the training instead of transferring out of it. Underneath all the returning stands the promise that makes returning possible: "And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ" (Philippians 1:6). The completion of you is God's project, under God's guarantee. Your assignment is the next return; His assignment is the finished work. Paul gives the farmer's version of the same patience: "And let us not grow weary of doing good, for in due season we will reap, if we do not give up" (Galatians 6:9). A crop has a season. The man who quits in the middle of the field forfeits a harvest that was coming on schedule.

The step: If you fell today, return today — not after a penalty period of feeling bad enough. Confess it, receive the forgiveness, get up, and do the next right thing before the sun goes down.

The Hand That Holds the Fighter

Five movements, and not one of them heroic. That is by design. God keeps ordinary people by ordinary means, held inside an extraordinary promise: the founder and perfecter of your faith does not misplace His own. Your grip on Him was never the thing holding you. His grip on you is. If this piece has put words to your war, do one more thing this week: read **Galatians 5 and 6** slowly, the way you'd read a letter written to you. There is the war named — flesh against Spirit,

with no truce offered. There is the fruit promised, the fruit no fighter can manufacture and every Spirit-led walker grows: "But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law" (Galatians 5:22–23). And there are the burdens carried shoulder to shoulder, the reaping that comes in due season, the God who is not mocked and who is not finished. Read it, mark it, and bring this week's fight into its light — then get up, and keep coming back. He will complete what He began.

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